James Dean is Dead! (Long Live James Dean)

By Jackie Skarvellis

DEAN: Some crash huh? Whatta way to go, one helluva way to go! Oh, I never thought I'd die, not in the way I did! Steering wheel through my chest, broken ribs, broken neck, I was a mess. But, hey! That's show business! So, where shall I begin? Twenty four summers, young enough to feed the legend! Live fast, die young!

It's my last day on Earth, I keep reliving it. I was on the crest of a wave that day. In love with speed . . . Going fast, faster still, as fast as I can: slam my foot down. There's something coming, something in the way, roadblock? No, another car coming straight for me. He's gotta see me, gotta stop! STOP! *(Car crash.)* Limbo! Reliving my life over and over again! They won't let me go - they'll never let me go!

INTRODUCTION

James Dean once said . . . "If a man can bridge the gap between life and death, if he can live on after he's dead, then maybe he was a great man," And if this is the measure of greatness, James Dean had it in spades.

On September 30, 1955 James Dean died in a high-speed car crash at the age of 24 and today, more than 60 years after his death, he continues to be immortalized around the world. This selection bring us into his world as he reflects on his life and his death.

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DEAN: Immortality, that's all that matters. That's all that counts in my book. If a man survives in people's minds after his death: that's real fame!

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And I got that now. From where I am I can see them standing there in lines, queuing up to do just what I done, the same thing: the Death Ride! Long rows of 'em, a never-ending stream of kids: all clones of me. They're even dressed the same: tight blue jeans, white t-shirt, red nylon zipper jacket, same haircut, same style, they walk like me, they even try to talk like me - to be me! That is fame. I got it at last, but I had to die to get it!

Time, that's what it's all about. Timing: split second precision. Timing: an actor's gift. If I could just cheat time by going fast enough, fast enough to break the sound barrier, fast enough to always stay young, to meet eternity - yes siree! To go fast enough to cheat time - death can't be considered because if you're afraid of death, there's no room in life to make discoveries!

About a week before I died I had my picture taken in this coffin. Don't know why, just had this sudden urge to lie down in this coffin, have my picture taken. It was at Hunt's Funeral Parlour, where they fixed Momma for burial, made her look real pretty. I was on this photo shoot trying to get my face on the front cover of *Time* magazine when we came to Hunt's. I just got in and told them to 'shoot'! *Time* turned it down, bastards! Maybe all great actors are psychic, that's how we do what we do. We're very special people picked by God to be his clowns, and that is why they love us - our public. Razzle-dazzle them - I always do!

(flashback to Dean's first time in NYC)

The city's strange, big scary neon. I'm just a small-town boy from a hick

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town. Country boy, farm-hand, that's me! I don't fit in anywhere. There's people bought and sold in this city like it's a butcher's shop. Buyers and sellers eye each other up - like the meat market hanging on a hook. That one's tasty, that one's got too much fat, that one's lean and sinewy just like being on the meat rack. Street traders evaluate your worth, calculate your flesh. . . . They don't think I'm good enough, they laugh at my accent. I'll show them. I'll show 'em what I'm made of! I can do any role - anything! Just gimme the chance, gimme a break. But of course they won't, unless I play the right kinda games.

You audition for them and they size you up if you're pretty like me. They eye you up and down like a piece of meat. They look at you like you're something on the menu. You stand in front of them and they say leaning back in their big fat armchairs: 'Hey, Boy!' They like to call you boy like you were some shoe shine merchant, 'Hey, Boy! Before I can cast you kid, I like to get to know my actors better! Know what I mean?' I read between the lines. I smile and nod. Walk into the bedroom and he kicks the door closed behind. Takes his jacket off. I take off mine. We stand facing each other like a couple of cats, or two cowboys having a standoff. He approaches me and grabs my belt. Hard. 'Get my drift boy?' 'Sure,' I say and give him a smile, more a grin really, a knowing sorta grimace. And I sure as hell get his drift.

It opened lotsa doors when I was broke and down on my luck - desperate for a job, I'd do anything. I did anything. You have to make a choice and take that chance. Life here's too tough not to. You gotta work to eat right? I made the decision. Whatever it takes. I had to do it - even if it

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hurt. They used boots, belts on me. And cigarettes. Cigarette burns all over my flesh. They used my body to stub out cigarettes. In time I got used to it. Hell! I even started to enjoy it! At least with pain you know you're alive!

Hollywood fanfare/White Out.

USA rules, **OK?** It's 1950, we're gods. It's the Land of Opportunity! I'm picked for a Pepsi-Cola ad on TV and I stand out - the director likes me. This leads onto lotsa other things, and the director always likes me. That's when they're not screaming at me for being difficult, being late, being moody, not knowing my lines. They just love me. But I always stand out in a crowd. I'm not made of the stuff to be an extra. And they notice me because I'm different. . . *The Little Prince.*

The Little Prince. Like my Bible that book was, I read it over and over again, it became my credo. It's about this little guy from another planet who falls to Earth in the Sahara desert where he meets this pilot whose plane has crashed. But before that he meets a fox and the fox tells him a secret, a secret so precious that he whispers it and the secret is this: 'That it is only with the heart one can rightly see. What is essential is invisible to the naked eye.' I've lived by that credo all my life. The Little Prince who fell to Earth like a star, briefly lighting up the sky with gold. I didn't know it at the time, but that was me. I was that Little Prince. Just like a star that falls to Earth and dies before his time.

So, it's 1952 and I'm accepted into the Actors Studio in New York. God, that's a big break for a boy like me. I can't believe my luck, walking

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through those doors where all the greats have gone, and Lee Strasberg: Master of Ceremonies! 'You have a talent, but it is undisciplined. What you do is simple and believable, it has a wonderful quality', so far so good. But then it all turned sour like so many things in my life seem to do. I do a piece that I prepared for him, it was a last minute decision to change the scene and, boy, that one big mistake: 'It's crass! It's crap! Call that acting? Call that a performance? You oughta been a cowhand!', and on and on. He knocked the guts outta me. And an actor's gotta have guts, or what's left? Time to do the rounds, endless knocking on unending doors, rejection after rejection - that's something you gotta get used to when you're an actor. It destroys your soul. I didn't just knock, though, I hammered like hell!

The loneliness - I scream inside my skin, inside my skull. There's nowhere so lonely as the big city. I try and keep myself busy: I take lessons in dancing with Eartha Kitt; I take classes - anything to keep the void at bay. The city never sleeps and neither do I. It's all part of my training, I tell myself, to break new ground with my acting technique. I tell myself it's all good experience. *(Laughs.) – Flash to an audition scene*

Hi! Jimmy Dean! Yes sir, I brought a new piece from a screenplay by a friend of mine - oh, you don't wanna know what its called? Yeah, I play this guy who's all screwed up, right. .. ok. I got this thing, this illness, it's inherited, ya see. My Daddy was a no good bastard so he gave me this disease, it's congenital, it's in my blood, it's not my fault, I inherited it and, and ... No, it's not right, I'd like to start again, I think I got some words wrong - I'M TRYING TO GIVE A TRUTHFUL

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PERFORMANCE HERE, GODDAMMIT! Sorry!

I just wanna try again, I'm just getting into it now, give me a minute! I need more time. No, I am not wasting the studio's valuable time! Do you want a real performance by a real actor or just some manufactured shit? No! I'm sorry! What? You don't want me to do the speech again? Well, F*** YOU THEN! That's how it was: that's how I was! I took no prisoners, took no shit! Self-obsessed me to the bitter end. A bastard, but, it takes one to know one and bastards make the best actors!

The job I finally landed was in *The Immoralist* by Andre Gide. Great role for me! I hit all the headlines! The critics loved me - I was their darling, just for once! But then, at the very height of my fame, I quit! I handed in my two weeks' notice. They were stunned: they didn't know why. But I did! It was because at that time Elia Kazan called my agent and offered me the role of Cal in *East of Eden.* Now, I wasn't gonna turn down a lead role in Hollywood just to be on Broadway, now was I? Hold the bus!

Hollywood Fanfare.

Hollywood! Tinseltown! James Dean had arrived. The whole world knew my name. I was interviewed by all the press. *(flash to interview sequence)*

Mr. Harold Thompson, *New York Times,* pleased to meet you sir. No sir, I never did read the novel of *East of Eden,* I prefer the adaptation. New York? Love it! No, no, I didn't go to the premiere of *East of Eden* - too much pressure. Death? Well, it can't be considered, because, like I said

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before, if you're afraid to die, there's no room in life to make discoveries. Miss Parson, pleased to meet you! Please sit down! Best behaviour with this one, Louella can make and break reputations! Yes ma'am, truth is: I'm dog-tired. Three pictures, back to back almost. I need a rest! Yeah, they say I've done the Hollywood thing, but the truth is, I'm exactly the same as when I didn't have a dime. I need a break! Yes Ma'am, pleasure to meet you too. Phew! No, no more questions.

Three movies - that's all I made, just three little flicks: *Rebel; East of Eden,* and *Giant* - that's all! My whole legend rests on three motion pictures. When I was a kid, I dreamed of fame - not Hollywood as such, just fame. I never thought it would be like this: people staring at you in the street; stopping you in the street - Jeez! They must be desperate! It's like living by proxy, through a screen, through someone else!

People are dumb. They need something to latch onto, It's because they're empty inside so they need something or somebody to look up to, to worship, to imitate. That's why they become film fans. Movies make them come alive again. All of 'em sitting there lost and alone in the dark and then something happens. It's like the light of a star suddenly shines down on them and illuminates every corner of their pitiful lives, and it's magic! They feel the power of my fame, by proxy. It's almost like praying and God appears and throws a handful of stardust down on them.

It's my last day on Earth, I keep reliving it. . . . Another car coming straight for me. He's gotta see me, gotta stop! STOP! *(Car crash.)* Forever young and beautiful. Live fast, die young. I have to live with

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what happened - hear that sound? *(Crash.)* Again and again! Somebody, anybody, please help!

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AWARD HISTORY

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